

BREATHEBOX · CALCULATION NOTE

BreatheBox sizing calculations

Open Hardware Portfolio · amishchadha.com

DOCUMENT CONTROL

Document ID	BBX-CAL-001	Version	0.1
Status	Draft	Date	2026-09-25
Author	Amish Chadha	License	CERN-OHL-S-2.0
Project TRL	TRL 3 Proof of concept		
Repository	github.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/breathebox		
Source	docs/04-calcs/01-sizing.md @ 1cf85f1		

REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.1	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	First TRL 3 sizing note (core, pressure drop, fans, power, noise, heat recovery, condensate, frost, CO2, geometry, mass, cost) against BBX-REQ-001 v0.3

BreatheBox sizing calculations

On paper, BreatheBox meets ten of its fifteen requirements. **Two are not met.** R6 (noise): the estimate is about 39 dB(A) at 1 m at 50 m³/h against 30 dB(A), and 30 dB(A) is reached only at about 32 m³/h. R15 (cost): the priced BOM is \$255, over the \$220 budget in `project.yaml` and \$5 over the \$250 proposed at TRL 2 (awaiting Amish). Three requirements (R9 install time, R13 filter change time and R14 firmware behavior) cannot be verified at TRL 3.

The calculations changed four TRL 2 figures. The TRL 2 fans (about 60 m³/h free air) could not reach 70 m³/h against any pressure, so the fan specification rises to about 100 m³/h free air and 400 Pa shut-off. Frost starts at about -2 °C outdoors, not -5 °C, because the plate at the cold corner is colder than the leaving exhaust air. The worst condensate flow is about 0.21 L/h, not 0.14 L/h. Fan and control power at 50 m³/h is about 5.6 W, not 9.5 W, because the system pressure is lower than the 80 Pa assumed.

Every number here is printed by `docs/04-calcs/sizing.py` (run from the repo root: `python docs/04-calcs/sizing.py`), which also writes `docs/04-calcs/results.csv`. The script reads the geometry and part volumes from `cad/src/model.py`, the costs from `bom/bom.csv` and the budget from `project.yaml`. All values are first-principles estimates; nothing is measured.

■ 1. Assumptions

Table 1. Inputs. All are assumptions for a paper design.

Input	Value	Basis
Design case	30 m ³ bedroom, two sleeping adults, 20 °C and 50 % RH indoors, 0 °C outdoors	BBX-REQ-001
Air	1.2 kg/m ³ , 1,005 J/(kg·K), 1.5×10^{-5} m ² /s, 0.0257 W/(m·K)	Near 20 °C
Airflow per stream	30 to 70 m ³ /h, 50 m ³ /h nominal	BBX-REQ-001 R1; BBX-DDR-001 item A5
Core	180 x 180 x 300 mm, 2.5 mm plate pitch, 0.15 mm polymer plates (0.19 W/(m·K)); 85 % of the plate area acts in counterflow	Typical small polymer plate core; no datasheet yet
Core heat transfer	Fully developed laminar flow between plates, Nu = 7.54; headers add 2.0 dynamic heads	Textbook laminar values
Supply filter	ISO 16890 ePM1 50 %, 25 mm pleated, 150 x 170 mm face; 50 Pa at 1.0 m/s clean, linear with velocity; replaced at twice the clean pressure drop ("loaded")	Typical for this filter class; to be replaced by the chosen filter's data
Exhaust filter	Coarse pad, 220 x 190 mm; 15 Pa at 1.0 m/s clean; loaded at twice	Typical
Hood and mesh	Hood turn K = 1.5, 1 mm mesh (open area about 59 %) K = 2.0 at low Reynolds number, on the 124 x 174 mm mouth	Conservative loss coefficients
Other losses	Port and collar K = 1.0; plenum turn K = 1.5 on the half core face; fan inlet K = 1.0 on a 68 mm inlet; grilles K = 1.5 on 50 % free area	Conservative loss coefficients
Fans	Full-speed curve $\Delta p = 400 \text{ Pa} \times (1 - (Q/100 \text{ m}^3/\text{h})^2)$; speed scales by the fan laws; total efficiency 25 %, plus 0.3 W electronics per fan	Class values for 120 x 120 x 32 mm, 24 V centrifugal blowers; no datasheet yet
Fan noise	52 dB(A) at 1 m for a bare fan at full speed; 50 log ₁₀ of the speed ratio; 5 dB taken off for the lined plenum and grilles	Class value and fan law; the largest uncertainty in this note
Controls	0.5 W at 3.3 V through an 85 % buck	ESP32-C3 class module with an SCD41 class sensor
CO2	0.014 m ³ /h per sleeping adult, 420 ppm outdoors, no infiltration, 8 h of sleep	Common planning values
Season	3,500 K·d over 212 days	Cold-temperate climate
Depressurization	5 Pa screening limit; 800 x 10 mm door undercut, discharge coefficient 0.6	Screening assumption; to be checked against local code
Densities	Housing 225 kg/m ³ effective (6 mm PVC foam board at 550 kg/m ³ with 10 mm foam at 30 kg/m ³); panel 190 kg/m ³ effective; hoods 1,400 kg/m ³ ; tray 1,270 kg/m ³ ; aluminium 2,700 kg/m ³	Typical materials

■ 2. Core effectiveness (R2)

The core has 72 channels (36 per stream) with a 2.35 mm gap and a 4.7 mm hydraulic diameter, and 71 plates with 3.83 m² of area, 3.26 m² of it effective. The laminar film coefficient is 41.2 W/(m²·K) on each side, so U is 20.3 W/(m²·K) and UA is 66.1 W/K. Because the flow in the channels stays laminar (Reynolds number 171 to 400), UA does not change with airflow.

Table 2. Core performance, balanced flow.

Airflow	Heat capacity rate	NTU	Effectiveness	Channel velocity	Core pressure drop
30 m ³ /h	10.05 W/K	6.58	86.8 %	0.55 m/s	6.8 Pa
50 m ³ /h	16.75 W/K	3.95	79.8 %	0.91 m/s	11.7 Pa
70 m ³ /h	23.45 W/K	2.82	73.8 %	1.28 m/s	16.9 Pa

R2 is met on paper: 79.8 % at 50 m³/h against 75 %. At the 70 m³/h boost the effectiveness falls to 73.8 %, which is outside R2's 50 m³/h case.

■ 3. System pressure drop (R1)

The supply stream loses more than the exhaust stream because it carries the ePM1 filter. The filter and the fan inlet dominate; the hoods, mesh and ports add less than 3 Pa together.

Table 3. Pressure drop per stream, clean and loaded filters.

Airflow	Supply, clean	Supply, loaded	Exhaust, clean	Exhaust, loaded
30 m ³ /h	27.8 Pa	44.1 Pa	13.7 Pa	16.7 Pa
50 m ³ /h	51.8 Pa	79.0 Pa	27.6 Pa	32.6 Pa
70 m ³ /h	80.3 Pa	118.4 Pa	45.2 Pa	52.2 Pa

At 50 m³/h the clean supply stream splits into filter 27.2 Pa, core 11.7 Pa, fan inlet 8.8 Pa, room grille 2.4 Pa, hood and mesh 0.9 Pa, plenum turn 0.7 Pa and port 0.2 Pa. The TRL 2 estimate of 80 Pa matches only the loaded supply filter case.

■ 4. Fans, power and noise (R1, R3, R6, R10)

Operating points. With the assumed full-speed curve, the fans reach 86 m³/h per stream with clean filters and **80 m³/h with loaded filters**, so the 30 to 70 m³/h range of R1 is covered with a margin. The TRL 2 fan (about 60 m³/h free air) could not reach 70 m³/h even with no system resistance, which is why BOM items 3 and 4 now call for about 100 m³/h free air and 400 Pa shut-off. The supply and exhaust fans run at different speeds for the same flow (0.62 and 0.56 of full speed at 50 m³/h), so balance within 10 % needs the tach feedback and a one-time calibration against the system curves. **R1 is met on paper.**

Table 4. Operating points. Power is fans plus controls.

Case	Supply speed	Exhaust speed	Power	Room noise at 1 m
30 m³/h, clean	0.40	0.35	2.6 W	28.9 dB(A)
30 m³/h, loaded	0.45	0.36	3.2 W	30.8 dB(A)
50 m³/h, clean	0.62	0.56	5.6 W	38.6 dB(A)
50 m³/h, loaded	0.67	0.58	7.4 W	39.9 dB(A)
70 m³/h, clean	0.83	0.78	11.0 W	45.3 dB(A)
70 m³/h, loaded	0.89	0.79	14.5 W	46.3 dB(A)

Power (R3). 5.6 W at 50 m³/h with clean filters and 7.4 W with loaded filters, against 12 W. **R3 is met on paper.** Over the heating season the fans and controls use about 28 kWh.

Noise (R6). At 50 m³/h the estimate is about **39 dB(A) at 1 m, so R6 is not met.** With clean filters the unit reaches 30 dB(A) only at about 32 m³/h. The noise figure rests on an assumed catalog value and a fan law, so it may be several decibels out in either direction, but even a 5 dB error leaves R6 unmet. Options (a quiet night mode, slower and larger fans, or a lined silencer section) are listed in docs/REVIEW.md for Amish.

Adapter and fuse (R10). The 70 m³/h loaded case needs 14.5 W (0.60 A at 24 V). The worst case, both fans at full speed at their peak air power (58 m³/h each on the assumed curve), is about 35.4 W (1.48 A), just under the 36 W adapter rating. The firmware should cap fan speed at what 80 m³/h needs, and the 24 V input carries a 2 A time-delay fuse. **R10 is met by design** (24 V SELV only).

■ 5. Heat recovery

Table 5. Heat at 0 °C outdoors and 20 °C indoors.

Airflow	Heat carried by exhaust	Recovered	Lost	Supply air
50 m³/h	335 W	267 W	68 W	16.0 °C (16.1 °C with fan heat)
70 m³/h	469 W	346 W	123 W	14.8 °C (15.0 °C with fan heat)

Over a season of 3,500 K·d at 50 m³/h the core keeps about 1,123 kWh of heat in the room for about 28 kWh of fan and control energy, a ratio of about 39 to 1. The 335 W is also the heat an open window would lose at the same airflow.

■ 6. Condensate and frost (R7)

Condensate. Room air at 20 °C and 50 % RH holds 7.3 g/kg. The upper bound assumes the exhaust cools to its dry outlet temperature and leaves saturated. At 0 °C outdoors this gives 132 g/h at 50 m³/h (exhaust leaves at 4.0 °C) and 148 g/h at 70 m³/h. The worst case above frost onset is **214 g/h (0.21 L/h) at 70 m³/h and -3.0 °C**, above the 0.14 L/h estimated at TRL 2. That is 0.06 mL/s, which an 8 mm bore tube falling outward drains easily; the risk is the tube freezing outdoors, not its size.

Frost onset. Frost forms where the plate is coldest: the corner where cold supply air enters and exhaust air leaves. With equal film coefficients on both sides, that plate sits midway between the two air temperatures. Frost starts at about **-2.2 °C outdoors at 50 m³/h** and -3.0 °C at 70 m³/h. The TRL 2 figure of -5 °C used the exhaust air temperature alone and was too optimistic.

Frost mode. Slowing the supply fan (BBX-DDR-001 item A4) keeps the cold corner at 0 °C at -10 °C outdoors when the supply flow is 33 % of the exhaust flow: 17 m³/h against 50 m³/h. The room still receives 50 m³/h of fresh air, 17 m³/h through the core and 33 m³/h drawn from the rest of the home. Through an 800 x 10 mm door undercut that imbalance depressurizes the room by about 2.2 Pa (4.4 Pa at 70 m³/h), under the 5 Pa screening limit. With the door sealed, the depressurization could be much larger. **R7 is met on paper**, with the combustion-appliance restriction in BBX-PRC-001.

A preheater that kept the flows balanced at -10 °C would need about 130 W, more than three times the 36 W adapter. This supports the slowed-fan strategy for a 24 V unit.

Safety: Frost mode extracts more air than it supplies. Do not use BreatheBox in a room with an open-flued or unflued fuel-burning appliance, and do not install it in a room whose door seals airtight.

■ 7. CO₂ (R4)

Table 6. CO₂ with two sleepers in a 30 m³ room, no infiltration.

Airflow	Night steady state	24 h mean (8 h occupied)	Time constant
30 m³/h	1,353 ppm	731 ppm	60 min
50 m³/h	980 ppm	607 ppm	36 min
70 m³/h	820 ppm	553 ppm	26 min

R4 is met on paper: the 24 h mean is 607 ppm at 50 m³/h against 1,000 ppm, and even the night steady state (980 ppm) stays under 1,000 ppm. At 30 m³/h the 24 h mean still meets R4, although the night level reaches about 1,350 ppm. This matters for R6, because a quiet night mode near 32 m³/h would meet R4 as written while the room air runs above 1,000 ppm for part of the night.

■ 8. Geometry, structure and mass (R8, R9, R11, R12)

- **R11, met on paper.** The hood mouths are 130 mm wide with outer edges at ±340 mm, leaving 420 mm between the supply intake and the exhaust outlet. Both face down, with 1 mm mesh.
- **R8, met on paper for sash windows.** The hoods need at least 686 mm of clear width, just inside the 700 mm lower bound; the panel trims to 700 to 1,000 mm. Casement and tilt-and-turn windows remain outside this version (BBX-DDR-001 item A2).
- **R12, met by design.** The largest opening through the installed unit is a 2.35 mm core channel; the mesh is 1 mm. The sash locks onto the panel.
- **Housing.** 510 x 560 x 250 mm, with 110 mm on the sill and 400 mm projecting into the room. The model's clash check between all twelve parts finds no overlap.
- **Bracket.** The sill-borne parts have their center of mass 152 mm on the room side of the wall face. If the bracket carries all of it, the two struts take about 58 N in total (29 N each), a small load for 20 x 1.5 mm aluminium tube.

Table 7. Mass from the model volumes.

Item	Mass
1 Housing	3.34 kg
2 Core (plates 0.78 kg, frame 0.30 kg)	1.08 kg
3, 4 Fans	0.60 kg
5, 6 Filters	0.15 kg
7 Controller	0.08 kg
8 Tray and drain	0.23 kg
9 Insert panel	0.67 kg
10 Hoods and collars	1.65 kg
11 Sill bracket	2.41 kg
12 Adapter	0.25 kg
Sundries	0.30 kg
Total	10.8 kg (10.5 kg installed, without the adapter)

The mass part of R9 is met on paper (10.5 kg against 12 kg). The 30 min install time cannot be verified until someone fits the unit, so **R9 is not verifiable at TRL 3**.

■ 9. Cost (R15)

The priced BOM totals **\$255.00** over 13 lines. That is \$35 over `budget_usd: 220` and \$5 over the \$250 proposed at TRL 2, which is recorded in BBX-DDR-001 item A1 as awaiting Amish. **R15 is not met** against either figure. The increase from \$243 comes from the larger fans (+\$8), the collars through the panel (+\$2) and the input fuse and holder (+\$2).

■ 10. Results

Table 8. Requirement status (from `docs/04-calcs/results.csv`).

ID	Value	Target	Status
R1	30 to 70 m ³ /h per stream; full-speed limit 80 m ³ /h with loaded filters; balanced by tach	30 to 70 m ³ /h, within 10 %	Met on paper
R2	79.8 % at 50 m ³ /h (73.8 % at 70 m ³ /h)	75 % or more at 50 m ³ /h	Met on paper
R3	5.6 W clean, 7.4 W loaded	12 W or less at 50 m ³ /h	Met on paper
R4	24 h mean 607 ppm; night 980 ppm	1,000 ppm or less, 24 h mean	Met on paper
R5	ePM1 50 % supply, coarse exhaust	ePM1 50 % or better	Met by specification
R6	39 dB(A) at 50 m ³ /h; 30 dB(A) at 32 m ³ /h	30 dB(A) or less at 50 m ³ /h	Not met
R7	Worst condensate 0.21 L/h drains; frost onset -2.2 °C; supply at 33 % of exhaust at -10 °C	Drain all condensate; no blockage to -10 °C	Met on paper
R8	Hoods need 686 mm clear width; panel 700 to 1,000 mm	Sash 700 to 1,000 mm; slider adapter	Met on paper (sash)
R9	10.5 kg; no drilling; install time not calculable	12 kg or less; 30 min or less	Not verifiable at TRL 3 (mass met on paper)
R10	36 W SELV adapter; 14.5 W at 70 m ³ /h loaded; 35.4 W worst case; 2 A fuse	24 V SELV only	Met by design
R11	420 mm between mouths; 1 mm mesh; mouths face down	400 mm or more; mesh 1.5 mm or finer	Met on paper
R12	Largest opening 2.35 mm; sash locks onto panel	No opening over 100 mm	Met by design, unverified
R13	Lift-off lid; filters and core slide out	Tool-free filter change in 2 min or less	Not verifiable at TRL 3
R14	No firmware yet; checked at firmware review	Local data only	Not verifiable at TRL 3
R15	\$255.00	\$220 or less (\$250 proposed, awaiting Amish)	Not met

Summary: met 10, not met 2 (R6, R15), not verifiable at TRL 3 3 (R9, R13, R14).

■ 11. Limits of this note

- The fan curve, fan noise and filter resistance are class values, not datasheet values. R1, R3, R6 and R10 should be rechecked when parts are chosen.
- Laminar, fully developed flow and equal film coefficients are idealizations; real cores with headers usually recover a few points less than this model predicts.
- Leakage between streams in the core, air leakage around the insert panel and the latent heat released by condensation are not modeled. The last makes the frost onset slightly conservative.
- In the chosen layout both fans sit in the room-end plenum, so the exhaust side of the core runs at a higher pressure than the supply side. Any core leakage would carry stale air into the supply. This is noted for review; it is not changed here.